



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with ID

Anonymous (ID)

30th May 2018

Location: interviewee's home in the Republic of Ireland

Interviewed by Ida Milne (IM)

Transcribed by Ida Milne and Olivia Dee

The interview with ID took place in her home in the Republic of Ireland. She explained that she spent time in two Good Shepherd mother and baby institutions and one St Mary's Home/laundry in Northern Ireland during two separate pregnancies in the 1960s. On both occasions, the baby was adopted. It was after the birth of the second child that ID was transferred from the mother and baby institution into the St Mary's home where she worked in the laundry. She describes the fear she felt when wondering whether she would be allowed to leave the St Mary's home. She did leave after several months; first being transferred to another Good Shepherd laundry in the Republic of Ireland before her release shortly thereafter. Recalling her time in the Good Shepherd laundry in Northern Ireland, she remembers receiving what she believes was electric shock therapy and it is her concern about why this happened that provided one motivation for ID to offer an interview to the researchers.

We have maximised the anonymity of ID and those discussed in her testimony via the use of redaction of names and identifying locations. Areas where the transcript has been redacted are indicated by **.

IM: So, we are here in *location in the Republic of Ireland.* It is 30 May 2018.

ID: Correct.

IM: And this is an interview with an anonymous interviewee for the NI mother and baby home and Magdalene laundry investigation.

ID: That's right.

IM: And would you mind telling me your story.

ID: Ok, I'll start it, I was at boarding school, and I was writing a letter to my mother, complaining about the food, as usual, and I said that because of the absence of fruit in our diet, I was constipated and I hadn't had a period. And within what felt like hours my mother arrived at the school door with a doctor, and I was tested, and they discovered I was pregnant ... this would have been around about November and I would have been seventeen the following February; so I was late sixteen. I came home for Christmas.

IM: What year was it?

ID: *196*. Yes. I came home for Christmas, and didn't go back to school. My parents found friends who would hide me for a period of time and all the work was done behind my back. I knew nothing about it until I was brought to *location in Northern Ireland*, to the Good Shepherd Convent there. And my experience there were quite normal because it was so similar to boarding school. The only thing I can remember being shocked about in there was the sanitary towel, because it was a piece of cloth that was washed and reused. I had never seen or heard of anything like that before. We had no contact with the mother and baby home - oh, with the laundry section I mean. Or the orphanage or the, whatever else they may have had. I don't even know what they had. We were a separate unit. My daughter was born in *name of hospital redacted* and when she was

twelve days old, my mother came and collected both of us, brought us to Dublin to *name of adoption agency*. [Pauses] No, I don't remember [the agency's name]. I will remember it later, and she was adopted from there. *remembers location of adoption agency and names it*! And I came home. So, my experiences in *location of the Good Shepherd mother and baby home* were calm, unemotional; there were no problems of any sort while I was there. All of the mothers that had their babies, all lived, were satisfied with their conditions and their treatment. I can't say anything about it because it was just an extension of boarding school, for me. But then four years, five years later, I got pregnant again, when I was twenty-one. Which was in *196*. I was in England. I came home because my father died and then discovered I was pregnant, wrote to my boyfriend and of course that was the end of that relationship. So once again I had to say to my mother that I was pregnant and she obviously got in touch with the Good Shepherd nuns because she had had dealings with them before, and ... Oh, the reason why I went to *location of the Good Shepherd mother and baby home she went to during her first pregnancy* was to get me as far away possible as I could from *ID's home county*, where, because there would be less people that would know me. Because the options were Dublin, but because I could run into somebody who knew me in Dublin. So again the nuns agreed to accept me again, into *a different Good Shepherd mother and baby home in Northern Ireland*. And it was again into the mother and baby home, which was not as nice as *the mother and baby home she was in for first pregnancy*, but it was perfectly fine.

IM: So this was the Good Shepherd *location redacted*?

ID: Yes.

[Detail redacted]

ID: But, again, it [the second mother and baby home she was placed in] wasn't as nice, it wasn't as, as ... do you use the word upmarket? The building was older, the conditions were a little bit rougher. There was more dormitories, less single rooms. But, it was adequate for the job it was doing. And I had my son, and I was brought back not to the mother and baby home, but back into the laundry. My son went to *name of baby home in Republic of Ireland*. I brought him there on the train with another lady, and then came back and straight into the laundry.

IM: So this was immediately after his birth.

ID: Yes, immediately after, and there was no discussion with me about it, it was all arranged with my mother.

IM: Even though you were of age.

ID: Yes, I was twenty-two by then. Ah, and there was no end date, no release date, I was just told I was going to be kept there until my mother decided otherwise, and I had no say in the matter. And, but I got a reasonable job in the laundry in that I sorted out the clean laundry, and what hotel or restaurant it was going to go to, or whatever. As opposed to the harder jobs of actually washing the darned stuff. And ... I ... didn't know how to query what was happening, so I put up with it for a period of time, waiting for a time when I would say, okay, I can't stand this anymore and now I am going to have to do something. But in the meantime I'll just plod along. Very, very scared of my mother, always was, and now that my father had gone, even more, more dependent on her goodwill. So I didn't want to rock her boat too much. So I put up with it, and then one day, and the reason why I contacted ye, I was called to go to a local hospital. I can't tell you the name of the hospital, I'm perfectly certain it was a Roman Catholic one, but other than that I don't know what it was. And I was brought into, I was brought

into the hospital, the lady with me, because you were never let out on your own, the lady with me was left in the waiting room, and I was brought in and put on a bed and given an injection. And sometime later I woke up, very groggy, took me a while before I could sit up, another few minutes before I could actually put my feet on the floor. And then gradually came too, and I sat there until somebody came in and said “okay, you can go back now”. And that happened to me for between six and eight trips. The distance between them I think was only a week, but I could be, I could be very wrong. It is so long ago, I could be very wrong. And then life went on. And finally it came to Christmas of that year, and I was coming up to my twenty-third birthday, and I was sent to the Good Shepherd laundry in *location in Republic of Ireland*, for about five or six weeks. And then I was allowed home, and life went on. I [*emphasis*] believe now that I had electric shock treatment [*slowly and with emphasis*] I do not know who authorised it, because no doctor ever examined me to say do you need this, do you want this? Did I consent to it? If I signed a form, then I did, but I would not have had a clue what form I was signing. Nor why I was signing it, because at that time when you were told to sign a form, you signed the form, because it was only either my mother or the nuns to tell me this and both of them were, were my, my controllers. I never heard any more about it from anybody. If the nuns got the report for whatever this was, they never sent it to me. They may have sent it to my mother; my mother certainly never said it to me. I have often wanted to contact all the Catholic hospitals in *location redacted* and say would any of you be the one, and my dates are quite rough, and it is so long ago, and what records [would] they have left? Goodness only knows. But I would also like to know.

IM: So you think this might have been *196*?

ID: It was *196*. I got pregnant shortly after my twenty-first birthday, which was *date redacted*, so it was *date 9 months later* when my son was born. Had to

be *date redacted 1960s* because I came home just before the *month redacted*. That I would have been *196*. But I ... if this was something that the nuns did to young women who had had two children or more, I would like to know on what grounds they felt they had the right to do this. Was this supposed to put us off sex? Or what on earth, or what was it [*animatedly*]? Was it a shock treatment, was it something different, was I, you know, having epileptic fits that I didn't know about that they were going to shock out of me or something? I didn't know what, but I would like to know.

IM: And they never told you why?

ID: [*With emphasis*] Never. Never. And the lady who came with me, she was a trustee, she came everywhere with us, whether you were going to the dentist or the doctor. She wasn't a nun, and she wasn't a Magdalene.

IM: Do you have a name for her?

ID: No. No. But she was the only one. Each convent had one. Because *the Good Shepherd laundry ID was sent to in Republic of Ireland* had one as well. So if someone had to go to the doctor or the dentist, or do some shopping, this one woman did, it, all the time. And you know there were layers within the *penitents* [ID laughed and emphasised the word]. There were the unmarried mothers, then there was the women who worked in the laundries, and then there was a group called Magdalenes who weren't nuns but wore habits like the nuns. She was not one of those. She was simply a trusted ordinary worker, who if she had no jobs to do would work in the laundry with everybody else. But, if something had to be done outside she was the one who did it.

IM: And do you think she had come through the system as well?

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ID: Oh yes, yes, but possibly she had no place to go to.

IM: Yeah.

ID: And had decided she would stay there because at least it was a guaranteed roof over her head. And goodness knows what options she too had had in her time, because, to me she was an old woman. She was probably forty, but she was very, very old [laughs]. But she never mentioned it [ID's unexplained hospital visits] to me again. I do remember the last time I went there, when we were coming home, she said to me that they had told her that this was going to be the last time that she would bring me.

IM: Do you think she said that as a kind of comfort to you?

ID: I think it was simply a piece of information, you know, don't come looking for me next week, because...

IM: And she didn't say, oh sorry you are having to go through this, or how do you feel....?

ID: No, no, no, no. And I wouldn't even think she would have known what I was going through. I think like a lot of us there, she didn't question. It was something you didn't do, and it was something I had not done in my life as a child with my mother, anyway, so I was quite happy to not question ...

IM: I think that is perhaps something that is very hard for a younger generation than us to understand, that we didn't question, and that's why so many of these

things happened. Would you see that, that it was not that different to what you experienced in life.

ID: Yes, yes, that is right. It wasn't. It wasn't. Except that the sanitary towel was the thing that stuck out in my memory, but, but other than that, it really was pretty much gaol at home, it was gaol there.

IM: I suppose for the purposes of the tape and for people who might not realise what the norm was at the time, was what we would have had packets of sanitary towels with kind of loops on them.

ID: Absolutely. Yes, yes.

IM: And a sort of belt that you would wear them on.

ID: And I should say that each packet came with a little slip, so that the next time around, so that you didn't have to ask the chemist the next time around. You handed him the slip, so that nobody heard, what you were saying, because there might be a man there who would hear it and who might be shocked.

IM: And even in the '70s when I was growing up at home, they would come home wrapped up in brown paper.

ID: That's right, always brown paper.

IM: So that nobody could see them and nobody in your family knew.

ID: That's right, yes. Yes. Yes. But you asked about things like mortality rates?

IM: Mmm.

ID: Again, nobody died, adult, child or otherwise, during my time in either convent. In the *the second Good Shepherd convent in which ID was placed* I did mix with some orphans. At least I presume they were orphans because they were children. Probably because they were obviously phasing them out, because there was only about six children, there while I was there. And they had a little contact, not very much, but they did have a little. They had more with the Magdalenes, the ...

IM: So they were in a home rather than in *name of a Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted*, as such?

ID: Yes, because, but probably because there was so few of them, they mixed more with us than they would have in the past. And the nuns were kind to them. That I remember, that they were kind. And the children loved them. But then of course the children loved them because of course they had never known anybody else, but, but them. But still they were loved and that was nice.

IM: Were you expected to do jobs then?

ID: Oh, all the time. In both convents. In *name of mother and baby home in which ID spent her first pregnancy*, we did jobs. But apart from cleaning our room there was not an awful lot of jobs that we did. But we knitted and sewed ... we knitted for our own babies, and we knitted for other babies, and we sewed for them. And it was more an occupational therapy than jobs, just ... our rooms cleaned, our catering areas cleaned. As one would any place that one lived. In *name of Good Shepherd convent in which ID spent her second pregnancy* there was a laundry, and it was all the heavy work of the local hotels and restaurants

mainly, there was some private houses, that sent laundry there, but there were not a lot. It was mainly the hotels, oh, and of course, the priests, they all sent their laundry there. There may have been other convents, I am not certain, but it was all big items, it was not the usual shirt, vest and underpants, it was the tablecloths.

IM: From the priests ...

ID: No, no, from general, it was a big laundry, yes. And it was washed, it was ironed. It was sorted, it was ... the whole lot.

IM: Yeah. In terms then, did you experience any particular cruelty, obviously that time which you think was the ECT and it certainly sounds like it.

ID: [*Considered*] No. I had a terribly disturbed, cross mother and then I had boarding school, and they were all to be ... me ... just ... they weren't cruel, not deliberately cruel. They were not pleasant, far from it. The diet was very basic. You never saw a piece of fruit, from one end of the year to the other. You had no library. That might give you notions above your station. Ah, you had no entertainment, and yet you were not allowed talk about yourself. You know, I never saw anybody play ball, or, or I never swam. There was no such thing as chess or draughts, or Ludo, or packets of cards.

IM: Which would have been the norm in outside society at the time.

ID: Absolutely, absolutely, yes. Yes. And pre-televisions there would have been lots of things like that of every age we would have played in the evenings, sitting around a fire. I don't remember a record player. I do remember in *location of mother and baby home in which ID spent first pregnancy* that there was a radio. I don't remember a radio in *location of Good Shepherd convent

where ID spent her second pregnancy/was sent to the laundry*. I certainly never heard any news, and I would always have been a bit of a news fanatic. I don't remember anybody coming and saying - the nuns might have listened to news - I don't remember any of them coming and saying "so and so was elected", or "so and so lost his seat" or whatever. And they probably would have been listening to Northern Ireland news anyway and I would have been more interested in the South.

IM: No chatter about *major historical/newsworthy incident redacted* or anything like that.

ID: [Discussion of that event and date redacted] Yes he did of course, yeh ... I do remember one day, whatever I was doing, I looked out the window and there was a lot of men outside in the garden, and I was told: "Oh come away from the window they're B Specials." And I had not a clue, I'd never heard of a B Special before. And when I asked, and they did not even want to tell me, those people are so scary, that they didn't want to tell me what a B Special was. So I was just told to drop it, and you know, walk away from it. But no, there was no ... I can't think, I am sure we continued to knit, and I am sure we continued to sew, but I can't remember what we did for entertainment. But then we worked.

IM: Did you do anything like make priest's vestments, or anything like that?

ID: No, no, no, no. We didn't no, nor hosts for the communion. None of that, none of that was done by us, we were a laundry.

IM: And I am just curious because my mother has some absolutely beautiful sheet music made by the Magdalenes in Dublin, did you do anything like that kind of thing?

ID: No, no, we didn't.

IM: Can we go back then, you were talking about the accommodation not being as good in *mother and baby home/laundry where ID was sent at time of second pregnancy* as it was in *mother and baby home where ID was sent at time first pregnancy*, so could you tell me what the accommodation in *first mother and baby home* was like?

ID: In *location of first mother and baby home* I had a room to myself with a wash hand basin, I went to the bathroom for my shower or my bath but I could wash myself in my room. My laundry was taken away once a week because we had no facility for laundry. So, it obviously went to *the* laundry, and our clean linen was brought to us. And we wore our own clothes. I don't think everybody had their own room. I think it is possible that because I was from down South there was no state support for me, so my parents may have had to pay something which is why I got the special treatment. I remember very little of *second convent/mother and baby home*. I remember the shape of the sitting room, and how we all sat around the edge of the wall, with one nun obviously in the room at all times, and we would talk about things that were amusing or interesting or whatever, amongst ourselves, as in our favourite food or favourite recipe, or our favourite dress, or the one that we were making at that particular moment and the problems that we were having with it. That's really about it, and of course we were never let out, except to go to a doctor, and we all went in a group, and we all wore brass rings as though we were married. So ridiculous, as if anyone cared a hoot.

IM: And when did you put those on?

ID: As we were leaving the convent.

IM: So you would not have them on all the time?

ID: No, no, anyhow they were cheap and would have gone black with wear. They did anyway but ... it was just in case there was somebody in the doctor's waiting room when we were there that we'd have these rings on our fingers ...

IM: So do you know how often would you go to see the doctor, and was it kind of a collective appointment, if you all went ...

ID: Oh, it was, it was.

IM: And how many of you might there have been going at the same time?

ID: There weren't a lot of us in *location of first mother and baby home*: would there have been between twenty and thirty? At all different stages, but some of them had had their ... no ... some of them would have had their babies but they would have been gone within a fortnight of having their babies. They did not hang around in, in *location of first mother and baby home*. There might have been thirty of us, and ... But only about five or six would have gone at any one time to the doctor, so it was probably a weekly visit.

IM: Do you remember the name of the doctor, by any chance?

ID: No, No.

IM: But it was walking distance?

ID: Yes, yes.

IM: And from *location of first mother and baby home* when you went to give birth, you went to *name of hospital* as well?

ID: Yes. Yes.

IM: And do you remember anything about that. How did you know you were in labour?

ID: I didn't. Oh, my waters broke, yes my waters broke. I was in *name of hospital* for maybe thirty-six hours before I went into labour. *Name of hospital* was lovely, again it was a private room, and I remember they brought a menu around every day. And I was so impressed with this, I wanted to stay there. And then I had my daughter, and she came back with me, as I say, for twelve days, until my mother came and brought us to Dublin. The birth itself I remember very little of. I think I remember somebody telling me I had a girl, and I remember being very pleased as someone told me it was easier to have girls adopted than boys, particularly in America. God knows where I've got that memory from, but I am dragging it up from my boots. I don't remember the first time I saw her, but I remember the twelve days that I had her, because I went into a dormitory at that stage, with other, I think four other mothers and their children.

IM: This is back down in *mother and baby home in which ID spent first pregnancy*?

ID: We would wake up when every baby cried, and then wake up when our own cried, so we thought we had been awake all night, for the twelve days ...

IM: You must have been so tired, were the babies in the room with you?

ID: Yes.

IM: And in the bed with you?

ID: No, no. In the room with us.

IM: And you fed them yourselves?

ID: Yes, [corrects herself] oh, no, bottle feed, as we were not allowed to feed them ourselves as they were going to go within a couple of days. It would have been hard for the baby.

IM: Okay, so because the baby would have had to adjust, rather than you.

ID: That is right. Yes. But there was no, certainly no counselling, but there no talk of what happens next. We were told on X day your family will come and you will go home, so be packed and prepared and ready...

IM: Did you know what was going to happen to your baby, then?

ID: I always had assumed, that she would be adopted. Yes. Yes. We have met since, we've been in contact. Hasn't not worked out, but we were in contact.

IM: Where did she go to, do you know?

ID: She was adopted. She was reared in *location in Republic of Ireland*, and she was sent to live in *location overseas*, and is still there, but she was reared

in *location in Republic of Ireland*, by a couple who also had an adopted son and obviously they could not have any children. She had a very good life. As I say we, my mother brought me to Dublin, we went into *location redacted*, we went into a building there belonging to *name of religious order*, possibly, where I did all the paperwork, and I remember, I remember, for some unknown reason one form stuck in my head. I don't know how many forms I had to sign, but I had to sign a form that said I had taken out an insurance policy on my child ... that I would transfer it to the adopted parents, which I thought was, I don't know what I thought it was ... I thought it was strange, but I thought it was horrible for some reason. [At this stage, ID became upset] ... Not that they should benefit from my insurance policy, nothing like that. But that ... they were taking *everything* from me. Oh, I am going to start crying again, sorry. I am okay, I am okay, thanks. I think the lack of control *hit* me at that point ... badly. Because up to then, it was part of the norm, and I accepted it. That one hit me. Didn't hit me again the next time I had to go through the same procedure, because I expected it. But it hit me then. But that was, that was ... yeah but as I say, my memories of *mother and baby home where ID spent first pregnancy* were, are poor, partly because my second pregnancy was more recent. Even though it's only a couple of years in between, I was more adult, I knew what to expect. I was more aware of what was going on around me and ...

IM: Maybe a little bit more in control of your own life too, because you'd been away and you had a different life?

ID: Em, a little, a little.

IM: Just from what you are telling me, about your mother and that you had been in England, and...

ID: Yep. Yeh. That was her idea too [laughs].

IM: And did she find a job for you to go to?

ID: Yes, yes, I went *occupational detail redacted*, not because I had any interest in it, I couldn't stand it, but because I owed a debt to society.

IM: She told you, or you thought ...

ID: Oh she told me. I didn't think [Laughs]!

IM: Were you in London then?

ID: No, I was in *name of city in England redacted*, and I was there for two years. And I thought out of it I would never get. But as I say my father died, and I came home, and I discovered I was pregnant, and didn't go back, and I thought, that solves another problem. And then I went to *location of mother and baby home in which ID spent second pregnancy*. I believe my brother drove me. I don't remember the journey.

The building was like an attachment onto the convent, not as modern as *name of mother and baby home in which ID spent first pregnancy* but still quite, quite pleasant, quite airy and bright. We did the same things during the day that we had done in *first mother and baby home*. We sat around and sewed and talked. I forgot to mention it but everybody's name was changed when they got to the door of the mother and baby home. At the time we were told that was because later on, in later years, when we met outside, that we would not be able to identify each other, but I think it was more of a control thing, that they were taking as much as they could away from us. No, you don't talk about your family, you don't

talk about your home, you don't talk about your friends, you don't talk about anything that, that has happened to you up to today. It is only from today on that you may discuss. So you can discuss what you are going to have for your lunch today, but you can't discuss what your mother used to give you when you were a child.

So, so they didn't change my name, I kept the name I was given, and I don't know why, in both convents I kept my birth name. The, yeah, the day-to-day routine was very similar, it was a larger community, a larger community of unmarried mothers. And a more sophisticated community. They were better educated, they were a more interesting group than the previous group, but then that could have been because I was older than I was in * mother and baby home in which ID spent first pregnancy*. But they were fine, they were kind. They did, one of the nuns did tell the other women that this was my second child, and that I was really a more fallen woman than the rest of them were. The others let it be known to me that this had been said to them. But it didn't bother them, they were just there to get on with their own lives, and they couldn't give a damn what I had or had not done. ... Going into labour, no memory of going into labour, no memory of going into the hospital ... no memory of coming home from the hospital with my son or how long he was with me. I do remember going on a train to *location in Republic of Ireland redacted* with him to the home that were going to find him his adoptive parents.

IM: So you were actually going to the home of his adoptive parents?

ID: No, no, to the, the convent home. Actually he was adopted in [the Republic] and remained, and grew up in [the Republic]. I remember bringing him there, and I remember that I had a little gold cross and chain that I wanted to leave with him. It was the only thing I had, and I was told no, that (a) they would not take it, and

(b) if it was around his neck he could choke or something. Quite possible, but they did not let me leave it with him, and then I came back to the mother and baby home and found my bags had been packed for me, and they were in a corridor, on the way into the laundry section of the building, and I was called for and told “in you go” ... and I didn't ask any questions that I can remember. If I did I probably would have been told this is your mother's decision, because it would have been she who'd have said if she was taking me out ... and so I went into the laundry. And the women there were every age from twenty to ninety. There was one woman there who had been in Cumann na mBan, and I didn't know who Cumann na mBan were, so I didn't ask any questions. And I am kicking myself for my remaining years that I didn't. Oh gosh, the women there, they worked, they worked. Some of them worked out in the farm because it was self-sufficient. Some of them worked in the kitchens, and some of them worked in the laundries, but boy, they worked ... I, I, I can't tell you.

IM: Was there ever a stick for beating them with or anything like that?

ID: No because nobody ever stepped out of place. They, they, the rule of fear that we now read about was in the atmosphere but it was no longer necessary to be physically cruel because everybody knew their place and they got on with it. If any of us were tempted to do something stupid, the other women would protect you, and say, we are not going to allow you to do that, because you'll get into trouble, it would be bad trouble. I remember one woman running away, and ... and they didn't chase her. She was older than I. I think she could have been mid-thirties. They obviously said, what can we do if we chase her, we could not bring her back at her age, so they didn't. Here in the South they would have because I would have known stories of a lot of women from the local home, but there they didn't. I ... from the couple of weeks I spent down South in the laundry, really the two homes in Northern Ireland were much more civilised than they were down

here, at the time that I was in them. They ... I can't think of anybody ever wanting to step much out of line. As I say, the woman who ran away didn't tell anybody she was doing it. So I don't know what her motivation was, or ... or whatever. I just know we all woke up the next morning, and shock and horror that she wasn't there, and lots of whispers and if a nun came near us, we would stop whispering, because, we didn't want to be heard, but, we never heard any more about her. We do know that she was not followed. We did know that. I can't remember, I can't remember any of the nuns being worse than any of the ones in boarding school.

IM: Were you in boarding school in *name of town deleted* or ...

ID: No, in *location redacted*. And they weren't dreadful, it was just the times we lived in. Well they were pretty dreadful, but they did not know any better. They had come from a time that was worse than the one we were living in and they probably thought we were living in the lap of luxury, having a bath once a month, whether we needed it or not [laughter].

IM: That is another thing, how ... you were talking about how *name of mother and baby home in which ID spent first pregnancy* had washing facilities, but how did you have access to things like baths and...

ID: Yes, but on a rota.

IM: Just like boarding school.

ID: We had a special time. It was once a fortnight.

IM: Did you have maybe a group of baths where you'd go in and...

ID: No, I only remember one.

IM: One bathroom.

ID: Yes. Which is why there was an allocated time, and you went at that at time and that was it, and you were guaranteed hot water, because it was turned on when you were having your bath that morning at that time. And you were actually ... it was ... it wasn't when you got up in the morning, for me it was during the morning, because I would be dressed. I would have had breakfast, I was downstairs when my time came, and I would go up to have it. In *mother and baby home where ID spent her second pregnancy* ... I, yeah, it must have been something similar. I can't remember anything different. [There] the food wasn't good, it was very boring, very bland.

IM: Describe a typical day's food, then, what would you get for breakfast?

ID: It was mainly porridge. I don't ever remember any cereal, just porridge, and bread and butter. You got one slice of white and one slice of brown and you got an allocated amount of, piece of butter. I don't remember jams or marmalade, I don't remember coffee ... Lunch was probably ... lunch was probably good but it was so boring. It was probably a lot of roasts.

IM: So you did get meat?

ID: Oh we did get meat, and we had fish on Friday whether we liked it or not. But we had cabbage that was boiled to ...

IM: Murdered!

ID: Absolutely, and most other things the same. And we ... hardly ever had salads or things like that for our evening meal. It tended to be a boiled egg, or ... and I think we occasionally got baked beans and I think we thought they were a big treat. But again it was pretty much bread and butter and ...

IM: It sound relatively good food then, if a little bland.

ID: It probably was, because they were self-sufficient, they [grew] vegetables there, fresh vegetables. It was just that they were cooking for over a hundred people. And they weren't chefs. They were women ...

IM: And the style of the time was to overcook.

ID: Oh absolutely, absolutely yes. Because I do remember when I went there first I asked could I have some black pepper? And I was being a bit of a snob and stirring it a bit, and I knew I was doing that, but I decided I would like some black pepper. So the lady who did all the shopping, who took us out or whatever, she ... *name redacted*, mightn't that be right, might not be right but *name redacted* has just popped into my head. She went and got some black pepper for me.

IM: That was lovely.

ID: Yes, as long as you did not want Ferrari cars or cashmere sweaters they were okay. I had some money, ten or fifteen pounds when I went in, because my mother had given me some pocket money, and I had no way to spend it. So, that was there, and if I asked permission, *name redacted* would, would spend it for me. My sister had her first son while I was there, and I asked her to buy my sister a gift for the baby and she bought little pillowcases for his cot.

IM: That must have been very hard, when you were there giving away your baby and your sister was, I presume she was keeping her...?

ID: Yes, it was. Oh yes, absolutely, yes. She had, I was pregnant when I was her bridesmaid, when she got married. Yes ... it was hard ... but again being reared in a semi-Catholic background, certainly being educated by nuns, I had all the guilt that the nuns put on you. So this was my own fault and this was my punishment. And I deserved it, and my sister was married, and was a virgin when she was married, and so you know, she was entitled to the good things of life, and I wasn't. God, those nuns did a good job didn't they. Yup. But they weren't cruel, but they were not kind.

IM: Would they actually say things like that to you, they would let you know?

ID: Oh yes, Oh good lord, yes. Oh heavens above, yes.

IM: Can you think of a specific?

ID: Oh no, because it like was in the atmosphere, it was there. There were two nuns in Belfast who were extremely kind, one even more than the other, one very young one, she was not fully ordained or whatever. She was from County *location redacted* and she was gorgeous. And there was a nun that I worked with, I answered directly to who was the sister in law of *name of minor celebrity redacted*, and she was, she was kind. Most of the others were just there. And now and again the nasty remark might be made or the nasty deed might be done. Petty things ... sending you back to your room to comb your hair properly because they were not happy with the way it had been done first. You know we were in our twenties. I can't remember, the things that happened, happened every

day, they became the norm, but there was never anything of, if you don't behave we will keep you here forever, there was never anything like that. It was never nasty nasty, just petty nasty, a crowd of women, a couple of hundred women living together, nastiness comes out, and you sort of expect it. You don't remember it.

IM: Again like boarding school.

ID: Like boarding school, yes, yes. Yes.

IM: Tell me, you have spoken of some of the nuns coming not from the North, but from the South, what about your own people there, were they from all over the country or were they...

ID: No I was the odd one. Everybody else in both communities were from the North.

IM: And not from Scotland, or England or-

ID: No not in my time.

IM: And do you know how your mother got to hear of this, would it have been through the Good Shepherd...?

ID: It would have been, it would have been, yes.

IM: Do you ever think your mother might have had some background in ...?

ID: No, funny enough we discovered afterwards my grandmother did, but my mother would not have known about it. Doing the family tree we discovered when my grandmother was 16, she had a daughter, who went to *name of an industrial school redacted*, and she only died about five years before we discovered her existence.

IM: Ah, gosh.

ID: We had never known of her existence and my mother certainly didn't. No, no, my ... my mother was, I suppose my grandmother had hang-ups because of her own experience. She married my grandfather, and she was from the far side of County *location redacted*, married my grandfather and came to *name of town redacted* and never ever visited her family again. Her sister came to visit her, once, and my grandmother refused to see her, because she did not want this to come up, and she'd never told her husband. My grandmother married a second time and, and ... her first husband died, and her second husband was a policeman and my mother was then sent to *another location in Ireland*, for a year, to finish her education because they were afraid her life might be threatened because of who her stepfather was. So she had nuns, all her life, and my grandmother protecting her. And my mother had serious hang ups about sex. She had serious hang ups about all sorts of things, goodness gracious. But, no I don't think there was anything in her background that made her react to me as she did. I think she would have reacted to everybody as she did to me, and she certainly did to my older sister, she reacted.

IM: So there is you, and your older sister...

ID: [ID has redacted all details of the number and sisters and brothers]

IM: And are you the second.

ID: I am the second, I am in the middle of the second family.

IM: For someone who had hang ups about sex-

ID: Yes! She had a lot, she had a lot of children. Yep she did. But then there was no contraception.

IM: I was just going to ask that; how did you learn about the facts of life?

ID: By being pregnant. I was already three months pregnant when my sister said to me one day: “I think I had better tell you about babies”, and I got one hell of a fright. Because my reaction was then gosh, I could be pregnant, and of course I then discovered I really was. And when, during that time, my mother was having a row with me one day and she said: “Well at least you weren’t sly.” I said “What do you mean?” [Her mother replied] “At least you did not use a contraceptive.” I didn’t know what a contraceptive was and I had to go and ask. And then I was horrified, that she would think, that to bring an unwanted child in the world was better than using a bloody contraceptive.

IM: So even then you thought that.

ID: Yes, yes. But ... she was a product of her environment too.

IM: You are very ... I suppose, forgiving about everything.

ID: I am [age redacted], we are talking about when I was sixteen and twenty-one, and we are talking about a woman who was ... she’s there beside you [note:

reference to a photograph] ... a bit mentally disturbed. Not ... not ... not certifiable, but her environment, her upbringing, her experiences, the whole lot, had her behave as she behaved, and me as I behaved. I was a reader and she thought I would educate myself into the facts of life. She hadn't said anything to the [other] children who went before me. They happened to be luckier than I, or whatever, but she, she honestly thought that I would read myself into it. Whereas I, being reared as this little Catholic girl, would have run a mile from a book that had the word sex in it, on the basis that it was dirty, and I would be committing, sins, and all the rest of it. She never made that connection ... Neither did the rest of us at the time.

[ID's dog came in]

IM: He is trying to tell you something, here. I think he knows. Is there anything else that you would like to add to that?

ID: Nothing that I can think of. Nothing that I can think of, but I can get back to you, I am sure.

IM: Yes, of course, please do. It's been very ... you have been very quick to put your thoughts together, and we have probably gone through some things I thought would take two hours in less than an hour.

ID: Yes, it is something I have to live with. And work out for myself, and come to terms with, in as much as I have come to terms with it. My daughter and I met about fifteen years ago. She was certainly with me for my sixtieth birthday and I am *age redacted* now, so more than that. She found me. That was incredibly wonderful. I got a phone call from a social worker, who told me that my daughter was trying to find me. And I rang my sister, in floods of tears, and my sister

called me a bitch! And I thought oh, we are back to the horribleness of the time, and she said: ‘You get everything before me, you are even a granny before me’ [laughter].

IM: Isn't that lovely, and not what you expected!

ID: Not what I expected! I had to tell her immediately, I could not wait to see her. I had to tell her immediately. But no, not what I expected. My oldest brother started to cry, and he said the circle had, had, been completed.

IM: So I was wondering about that, because sometimes you find that the men are more reluctant than the women for them to come back, the men in the family can close in.

ID: Yes, yes. My older sister, my stepsister, the whole family have very little communication with her, I have never said anything to her about it, I haven't seen her in years. One of my brothers said if you want any money, let me know, and that was the coldest thing any of them said to me. The rest of them were absolutely brilliant. They were wonderful. And some of them met her while things were still good, and that was great ... As I said she has two children so I am a granny. I tried to make contact with my son, a couple of times. And, I waited until he was eighteen I think. And the first reply I got back was from his father, to say he did not want to have anything to do with me. And I thought that could be the father saying it, because he could see me as a threat. So I waited for a good while, like twenty years or so, and I contacted him again, and I got no reply. And the last time I contacted him was about four years ago. And not him, again, the agency, asking the agency to contact him in [the Republic of Ireland], and no reply. A reply from the agency ‘we got your letter’ but nothing...

IM: So when you say the agency that would be *baby home to which ID took her infant son*?

ID: Yes, yes, yes. Its name has changed over the years. And I don't remember it, but it is the same address, the same agency from which he was adopted. But I do know he is in *name of county redacted*. That is all I know. Yep, they did say that.

IM: Did you ever think that any money might have changed hands for the babies, or anything like that?

ID: No, no. No. That tended to happen with American families. As in, dreadful analogy, as in when you go to a pound to adopt a dog, you usually give them a donation, that possibly happened. That probably happened, that would be the decent thing to do. But no, there was no...

IM: Contribute towards the care so far, that kind of thing ...

ID: No, no. Oh, my parents did. While they were in, while they were in ... until they were adopted. My father paid two pounds a week for each of the, the, my ... sorry, for my daughter, my mother did for my son but he was adopted very quickly. My daughter took two years before she was adopted.

IM: Even though they'd said ... you thought that that was a good sign, that she was a girl.

ID: Oh, that she was a girl, that is right. It was the American thing, the Americans liked to adopt girls, but she was adopted in Ireland.

IM: So tell me, did she stay in *name of mother and baby home where ID spent first pregnancy* for that time, all that time?

ID: No, no, she stayed, the two of us stayed for the twelve days, she then came to *location in Dublin* and that is where she was adopted from.

IM: And she stayed there for two years.

ID: She stayed there for two years, yes, yes. My father was earning four pounds a week at the time, so two pounds a week was quite a struggle for him. Fortunately, my mother ...

IM: So two pounds would be paid for the baby? Sorry, fortunately...

ID: Fortunately, my mother was working as well so that, you know, we weren't dependent on his income. But had my mother not had her own employment, he would have had to pay two pounds out of his four pounds a week.

IM: So, she really was quite formidable in her own way, [several] children and work as well.

ID: Oh, very, very. Yes, yes.

IM: Maybe ... unless there is anything else, you wanted to add. The paperwork, you were, you were aware that you were signing things but you know, as of the day, you said that you signed what was put in front of you?

ID: Oh absolutely, I read it simply because my mother was talking to the nun at the other side of the table, and it didn't involve me [laughs]. No I was only

there, like a piece of furniture. I read the one document on the insurance and I didn't want to read any of the rest. I didn't know what ...

IM: And both, do you remember signing paperwork both times or ...

ID: Yes, I signed papers in *name of baby home to which ID took her infant son*.

IM: I don't know how you remember this ...

ID: Yes. I signed papers ... but I was expecting to sign papers and I did. I didn't read them.

IM: It was quite a trek, to go over there ...

ID: Yes, I went by train.

IM: To *name of city redacted*, presumably, and onwards.

ID: Oh, absolutely no idea. No idea. I wasn't on my own, and I just followed.

IM: You didn't have to make any decisions, you just ...

ID: No, no.

IM: And did you carry the baby?

ID: Yes.

IM: Not in a cot, or anything.

ID: No, no, it was just in a blanket, yeah. And the bits I had knitted all came with me.

IM: And did they all go with them then?

ID: Yes.

IM: Oh that's nice.

ID: Oh I don't know! I don't know if they go onwards with him. They wouldn't have fitted him probably by the time he moved on to his new parents. They would have been just put in with the rest of the baby's clothes for whoever needed them. That would have been sensible.

IM: Well thank you very much, that has been really, really useful.

ID: Thank you.

IM: We'll just shut off the recorders now.

End of interview.